

The Impacts of Working Remotely and in an Office

Research

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List of Abbreviations

Abbreviations Used in This Report

Abbreviation	Full Term
N	Number of respondents (sample size)
WFH	Working from Home

Abstract

This study examines the impacts of working remotely and working in an office on productivity, physical health, mental health, social contact, focus, and work preferences. Remote work has grown significantly in recent years and has become a central topic in organizational research and workplace policy. A survey was designed with ten questions and completed by 1,000 respondents from various industries, age groups, and current work arrangements. The dataset also included six demographic variables that allowed for a more detailed analysis of how different groups of employees perceive each work environment. The results show that a large majority of respondents believe working from home increases productivity and provides greater flexibility. At the same time, most respondents attributed greater physical health risks to remote work, and 66% believed remote work has a higher potential to cause mental health problems such as stress, anxiety, and depression. The survey also found that 61% of respondents feel more focused in an office setting, and 71% believe working from home limits contact with other people. When asked about their preferred work arrangement, 48% of respondents chose a hybrid model that combines remote and in-office work, while 33% preferred full in-office work and only 19% preferred working fully from home. The findings suggest that no single work arrangement is perfect for all employees. Each one comes with real benefits and real challenges. A hybrid approach appears to be the most practical and preferred solution for the majority of employees because it allows them to benefit from both environments without being locked into either one fully.

Keywords: remote work, telecommuting, office work, hybrid work, productivity, mental health, physical health, work preferences

Introduction

Remote work has changed over the past decade from a rare arrangement to a common part of how many organizations operate. Before 2020, working from home was available to some employees but was not widely practiced or encouraged. Most companies expected their employees to be physically present in the office for the majority of their working hours. That expectation changed rapidly for a large portion of the global workforce, and by 2021 remote work had become part of the mainstream working experience. Many organizations discovered during this period that their teams could function effectively without a shared physical workspace, and that discovery prompted a much broader conversation about whether the traditional office was still necessary at all.

This shift raised a lot of important questions about what remote work actually means for employees and organizations over the long term. Some of those questions are practical. Do employees get more done at home, or does the home environment create too many distractions? Other questions are about health and well-being. Does working from home lead to more stress, more physical discomfort, or more feelings of isolation? And some questions are simply about what people prefer. Given the option to choose freely, where would most employees want to work?

These are important questions because the answers affect real decisions. Organizations are choosing whether to bring employees back to the office, whether to allow permanent remote work, or whether to move toward a hybrid model that blends the two environments. These are not easy choices, and they affect everything from real estate costs and team dynamics to individual satisfaction and long-term productivity. Getting these decisions right requires understanding how employees actually feel about both work environments, not just what managers or executives assume they feel.

This study was conducted to explore exactly that. A survey was designed with ten questions that covered the most important dimensions of the remote versus office work debate. Those dimensions include prior experience with working from home, perceived effects on productivity, flexibility, time savings, physical health, mental health, social contact, and focus, as well as an overall preference for a specific work arrangement. The survey was completed by 1,000 respondents from a variety of industries, age groups, genders, experience levels, and current work arrangements. The size and diversity of the sample allowed for meaningful comparisons across different groups, which adds depth to the findings beyond what overall percentages alone can show.

Research on telecommuting goes back several decades and has produced a complicated picture. Some studies have found that working from home improves productivity and satisfaction. Others have found that it introduces new sources of stress, weakens social bonds, and creates challenges that are hard to predict from the outside. Bailey and Kurland (2002) noted in their early review that the evidence for clear productivity gains from telework was not as strong as many assumed, and that the real effects depended heavily on job type, individual factors, and organizational support. Understanding those conditions and trade-offs is still one of the central challenges in the field.

What makes this study useful is the focus on direct opinion data from a large and diverse sample. Rather than measuring objective performance metrics, this survey captures how employees perceive each work environment across multiple dimensions. Perception matters in this context. If employees believe they are more productive at home, that belief affects their motivation, their satisfaction, and their preference for future arrangements. If they believe that the office causes more stress, that shapes how they respond to workplace policies. The findings from this survey are discussed alongside the research literature to provide context for the patterns that emerge, so that the conclusions are grounded in both real data and peer-reviewed evidence.

Literature Review

Productivity and Performance

Research on telecommuting and productivity has been ongoing for decades, and the results have been more complicated than most people expect. Bailey and Kurland (2002) reviewed the existing telework literature and found that the evidence for consistent productivity gains was mixed. The real effects depended on how productivity was measured, what kind of work was involved, and how much autonomy employees had in their roles. They also found that managers' concerns about controlling remote workers and uncertainty about outcomes were major barriers to adoption. This early review set the stage for a long research debate that continued well into the 2010s and beyond.

A more direct and controlled answer came from Bloom et al. (2015), who conducted a randomized experiment at a Chinese travel agency. Employees were assigned to either work from home or continue working in the office for nine months. The results showed that home workers were 13% more productive than their office counterparts. About 9% of that gain came from working longer hours due to fewer breaks and sick days, and about 4% came from more output per hour worked. Home workers also reported higher job satisfaction, and the company saw its quit rate cut in half among those who worked remotely. This study is frequently cited because it provides rare experimental evidence that working from home can genuinely improve productivity under the right conditions.

Allen et al. (2015) took a broader view in their comprehensive review of the telecommuting literature and reached several important conclusions. They found that telecommuting was generally associated with higher job satisfaction, stronger organizational commitment, lower work stress, and better self-reported job performance. However, they also found that these benefits were not automatic or universal. The frequency of telecommuting mattered a great deal. Employees who telecommuted occasionally tended to report the strongest benefits, while those who worked from home full time often saw diminishing returns on well-being and relationship quality. This finding suggests that moderate telecommuting may be the most effective approach for most employees.

Gajendran and Harrison (2007) reached similar conclusions in their meta-analysis of 46 studies covering nearly 13,000 employees. They found that telecommuting had beneficial effects on perceived autonomy and work-family balance. However, employees who worked remotely more than 2.5 days per week tended to develop weaker relationships with their coworkers. This finding

highlights one of the central trade-offs in the telecommuting debate: the gains in individual productivity and autonomy can come at the cost of team cohesion and social connection.

Physical Health

Physical health is one area where remote work has been consistently linked to negative outcomes. Mann and Holdsworth (2003) compared the health experiences of teleworkers and office workers and found that those who worked from home reported more physical health symptoms than office-based employees. These included headaches, eye strain, fatigue, and musculoskeletal discomfort around the neck, back, and shoulders. The researchers attributed these findings partly to the ergonomic shortcomings of home workspaces, where employees rarely had access to the same quality of chairs, desks, and monitors that a professional office provides.

Sardeshmukh et al. (2012) found that telework increased physical exhaustion as a job demand. While remote workers gained autonomy and reduced commute-related fatigue, they also faced demands that came from the home environment itself. Interruptions at home, inadequate physical setups, and the absence of an office structure were all real challenges that added to the overall burden of remote work. These additional demands contributed to higher levels of physical and mental exhaustion in some remote workers, particularly those who lacked strong organizational support or clear role boundaries.

The physical dimension of remote work is often underestimated in policy discussions. Most conversations about working from home focus on productivity and satisfaction, but the physical toll of extended remote work on the body is a genuine and well-documented concern. A person who works at a kitchen table or on a couch for eight or more hours a day will very likely develop physical problems over time, regardless of how much they appreciate the flexibility of their arrangement.

Mental Health and Stress

The relationship between remote work and mental health is one of the most complicated areas of the research. Mann and Holdsworth (2003) found that teleworkers reported significantly more negative emotions than office workers. These included feelings of loneliness, irritability, worry, and guilt. The study also found that teleworkers experienced more stress overall. This result is somewhat surprising given that one of the commonly cited benefits of remote work is a reduction in office-related stress. The findings suggest that remote work replaces some stressors with different ones rather than eliminating stress altogether.

Sardeshmukh et al. (2012) used a job demands and resources framework to explain these mixed findings. They found that telework reduced some demands, such as commuting time and office interruptions, but introduced new ones. These new demands included role ambiguity, reduced access to supervisor feedback, and weaker social support from colleagues. When the new demands outweighed the benefits, job engagement declined and exhaustion increased. This framework helps explain why some employees thrive in remote work while others struggle with the same arrangement.

Lautsch et al. (2009) found that the mental health outcomes of remote work depended heavily on how supervisors managed their remote employees. When managers maintained frequent and open communication and prioritized information sharing over schedule monitoring, remote workers reported better well-being and less role confusion. This finding carries an important practical implication: the mental health effects of remote work are not fixed and predetermined. They can be improved or worsened depending on how organizations choose to manage their remote workforce. Good management practices can meaningfully reduce the psychological risks of working from home.

Social Contact and Isolation

One of the most consistently documented downsides of remote work is its effect on social relationships at work. Gajendran and Harrison (2007) found that while low-intensity telecommuting did not significantly harm coworker relationships, high-intensity telecommuting, defined as more than 2.5 days per week, was associated with noticeably weaker ties with colleagues. These weaker ties can have real consequences for team performance, trust, and organizational culture over time. A team whose members rarely see each other in person tends to develop different dynamics than one that shares a physical workspace regularly.

Golden et al. (2006) looked at the relationship between telecommuting and work-family conflict and found results that were more complicated than a simple improvement or decline. Telecommuting reduced the amount of work-to-family conflict because employees had more scheduling flexibility. However, it also increased family-to-work conflict because the boundaries between home life and professional life became much harder to maintain. Social isolation in this context was not just about missing coworkers. It was also about the difficulty of occupying multiple roles in a single physical space, where the demands of each role could easily bleed into the other.

Hislop and Axtell (2007) pointed to a specific type of social interaction that remote work eliminates and that is rarely discussed in policy conversations. It is not just formal meetings that are lost when employees work from home. The informal and spontaneous exchanges that happen naturally in an office, the brief conversations at the coffee machine, the quick question to a colleague at the next desk, and the hallway discussions that lead to unexpected ideas, are very difficult to replicate through technology. These interactions carry information, build trust, and maintain team relationships in ways that scheduled video calls often cannot match.

Flexibility and Work-Life Balance

Flexibility is one of the most consistently cited benefits of working from home, and the research supports this perception strongly. Kelliher and Anderson (2008) found that employees who had access to flexible working arrangements reported higher job satisfaction and stronger organizational commitment than those without such arrangements. However, they also found that flexible workers tended to work more intensively than their non-flexible counterparts. The freedom and convenience of flexible work came with an unspoken expectation of greater effort, a pattern the researchers

described as intensification. Employees felt they owed their employer more because they had been given more.

Felstead and Henseke (2017) found similar patterns in their analysis of remote working outcomes. Remote workers reported higher organizational commitment and job satisfaction compared to fully in-office employees. However, they also found it significantly harder to switch off from work at the end of the day. The blurring of the line between work time and personal time was a consistent theme, and it meant that the time savings from eliminating the commute were often absorbed by longer working hours rather than genuine rest. The study suggests that the flexibility of remote work is real but comes at a cost that many employees do not fully anticipate when they first start working from home.

Golden et al. (2006) added another layer to this picture by showing that the benefits of scheduling flexibility in telecommuting depended heavily on individual circumstances such as household size and the nature of family demands. A flexible schedule is not equally useful to everyone. For a parent with young children at home, flexible hours may be essential for managing daily life. For a single employee with fewer competing demands at home, the same flexibility may not feel as valuable or may even make it harder to maintain a clear separation between work and personal time.

Flexible Work Arrangements and Performance

The broader question of whether flexible work arrangements produce measurable performance gains for organizations has not been answered with complete certainty in the research literature. de Menezes and Kelliher (2011) conducted a systematic review of the evidence for a business case for flexible working and found that the results were inconsistent across studies. Some studies showed performance improvements, others showed no change, and a few showed declines. The researchers concluded that the evidence did not clearly support a universal business case for flexible work and that outcomes depended heavily on how flexibility was implemented and what kind of work employees were performing.

Allen et al. (2015) pointed to individual-level factors as a major explanation for this inconsistency. Employees who had strong self-management skills, clear role boundaries, and supportive supervisors tended to thrive in flexible and remote arrangements. Those who lacked these supports often struggled to maintain the same level of performance. This finding suggests that the success of any flexible work policy depends not just on the policy itself but on the organizational and individual context in which it operates. A flexible arrangement that works well in one organization or for one type of employee may not work at all in a different context.

Methodology

This study used a survey-based research design to collect data on how employees perceive remote work and in-office work across several key dimensions. Survey research is well suited to this kind of investigation because it can capture subjective perceptions and attitudes from a large number of

respondents in a relatively efficient and comparable way. The goal was not to measure objective performance outcomes but to understand how employees feel about different work environments and what they believe those environments do to their health, focus, productivity, and social life.

Data Collection

The survey data underpinning this research was collected through a structured Google Form designed to capture employee perspectives on remote and in-office work. A total of 1,000 responses were gathered, covering 15 variables including demographics, work arrangement, and opinions on productivity, health, flexibility, and overall preference.

Survey Form

The survey was administered via the following Google Form:

https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSfCRxE_2tu5QIhnXv9olb7pe52U97spqSQole63igx6g5F4-g/viewform

Response Data (Google Sheet)

All 1,000 form responses are stored in the linked Google Sheet, which serves as the live response source. The sheet can be accessed using the following URL and Spreadsheet ID:

URL:

https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1nMRqmnvqFIOMLhSi_ZqNSsL63m55VRBwJrRnuY-R7nE/edit?usp=sharing

Collection Period

Responses were collected between September 20, 2021, and September 28, 2022. The dataset includes 1,000 complete responses with no missing values across all 15 survey fields.

The survey consisted of ten questions. The first question asked whether the respondent had ever experienced working from home. The remaining nine questions asked about specific perceived impacts: whether working from home increases productivity, whether it prevents the respondent from going out, whether it provides more flexibility, whether it saves time, which work type is more likely to cause physical health problems, which work type is more likely to cause mental health problems, whether working from home prevents contact with other people, which work type is better for focus, and which work type the respondent prefers overall. All questions had a limited set of response options. Binary questions were answered with yes or no, and multi-option questions offered two or three predefined choices. This format was chosen to keep the survey accessible and to allow for clean quantitative comparisons across groups.

The survey was completed by 1,000 respondents. Six demographic variables were also collected: age group, gender, industry, years of professional experience, and current work arrangement. In terms of age, the largest group was respondents between 25 and 34 years old, at about 31% of the sample. Respondents between 35 and 44 years old made up around 27%. Respondents between 18 and 24 accounted for about 15%, those between 45 and 54 made up 18%, and those 55 and older made up about 9%. These proportions reflect a workforce sample that is weighted toward prime

working-age adults, which is appropriate for a study focused on work arrangements and workplace experience.

Gender was split almost evenly, with 48.4% male respondents and 47.7% female respondents. A small group of 3.9% identified as non-binary or other. The sample covered seven industries. Technology was the largest single sector at 22.6%, followed by Healthcare at 14.8%, Other industries at 14.7%, Finance at 13.5%, Education at 13.2%, Retail and Hospitality at 11.4%, and Government at 9.8%. This variety of industries was important because work arrangements and attitudes toward remote work differ considerably across sectors. A sample drawn from only one industry would not capture the full range of employee experience.

In terms of current work arrangements at the time of the survey, 40.3% of respondents described themselves as working in a hybrid arrangement, 30% as fully in-office, and 29.7% as fully remote. This distribution reflects the real diversity of arrangements that existed in the workforce by late 2021 and provided a useful foundation for comparing responses across groups with different day-to-day work experiences. Having nearly equal proportions of each arrangement type made the cross-tabulation analysis more meaningful.

The data was analyzed using Python. The pandas library was used to load the dataset and organize the responses. The matplotlib and seaborn libraries were used to create charts and visualizations for each survey question. Descriptive statistics such as frequency counts and percentage breakdowns were calculated for every question. Cross-tabulations were created to compare responses across demographic variables such as age group, gender, industry, years of experience, and current work arrangement. These cross-tabulations were central to identifying the patterns that made the results more informative than simple overall percentages alone.

Table 1: Sample Demographic Characteristics (N = 1,000)

Variable	Category	n	%
Age Group	18–24	152	15.2
	25–34	308	30.8
	35–44	272	27.2
	45–54	180	18.0
	55+	88	8.8
Gender	Female	477	47.7
	Male	484	48.4
	Non-binary/Other	39	3.9
Industry	Education	132	13.2
	Finance	135	13.5
	Government	98	9.8
	Healthcare	148	14.8
	Other	147	14.7
	Retail/Hospitality	114	11.4
	Technology	226	22.6
Work Arrangement	Fully Remote	297	29.7
	Hybrid	403	40.3
	Fully In-Office	300	30.0

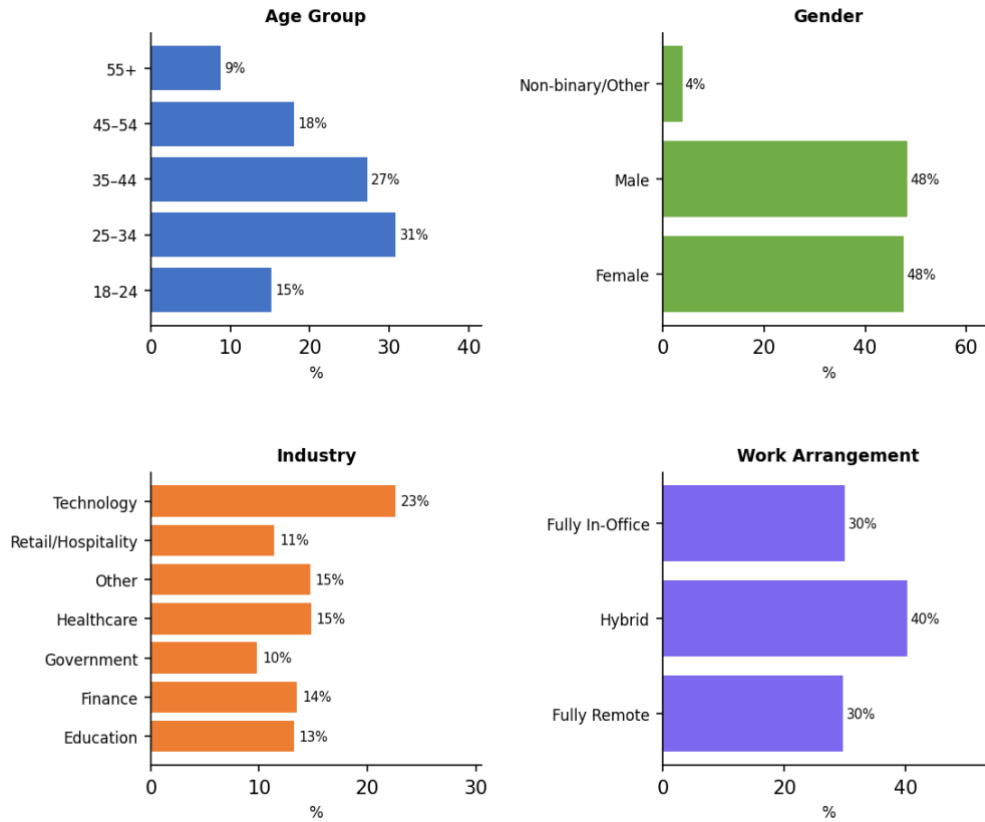


Figure 1: *Distribution of Sample Demographics (N = 1,000).*

Results and Discussion

Experience with Working from Home

The survey found that 65% of respondents had experienced working from home at some point. This is a significant majority and reflects how broadly remote work had expanded in the years leading up to this study. By 2021, working from home was no longer an unusual or niche arrangement for a large portion of the workforce. The fact that nearly two thirds of respondents had personal experience with it is important for interpreting the rest of the survey. When respondents express opinions about whether remote work is productive, healthy, or preferable, most of them are drawing on firsthand experience rather than assumption.

The 35% who had never worked from home were concentrated primarily in industries where physical presence is required. Healthcare and Retail and Hospitality workers were the most likely to report no remote work experience. This makes sense because patient care, in-store service, and hands-on operational roles cannot be performed remotely. This industry-level pattern is consistent with what Bailey and Kurland (2002) found in their review of telework research, where they noted that the suitability of remote work varied significantly depending on the nature of the job and the physical requirements of the role. Not all work is telework-compatible, and the survey data reflects that reality clearly.

This divide between industries that have experienced remote work and those that have not is also relevant to the broader policy conversation. When organizations debate universal remote or hybrid work policies, they sometimes overlook the fact that a significant portion of the workforce does not have the option to work from home at all. The experiences and preferences of front-line workers in Healthcare and Retail are just as important to understand as those of knowledge workers, even if the policies that apply to them are different.

Productivity

A large majority of respondents, 70%, said they believe working from home increases their productivity. This is one of the strongest findings in the survey and it aligns well with what the research literature has found for voluntary remote work arrangements. Bloom et al. (2015) measured an actual 13% productivity increase in a controlled experiment with employees who chose to work from home. That study provides strong evidence that the belief expressed by respondents in this survey reflects a real phenomenon, at least for employees who have the right conditions for productive remote work.

The picture becomes more interesting when responses are broken down by current work arrangement. Among respondents who work fully remotely, the agreement rate was 81%. Among respondents who work fully in an office, only 47% agreed that working from home increases productivity. This is a 34-percentage-point gap and it tells a meaningful story. People who have built their daily routine around the office are much less convinced that home is a better environment for getting work done. This could reflect genuine experience with in-office productivity, or it could reflect

limited personal experience with effective remote work setups. Both explanations are plausible and both are worth taking seriously.

The productivity question is also connected to autonomy, which is one of the key mechanisms identified in the research literature. Gajendran and Harrison (2007) found that telecommuting was positively associated with perceived autonomy, and that this autonomy was one of the primary drivers of satisfaction and performance gains. When employees control their own environment and schedule, they can organize their work around their most productive hours and minimize the kind of interruptions that an open-plan office sometimes creates. This autonomy effect is likely part of what drives the high self-reported productivity numbers among remote workers in this survey.

Allen et al. (2015) found that the productivity benefits of telecommuting were strongest for employees who telecommuted at moderate rather than full-time levels. This pattern was not clearly reflected in the survey, but it provides important context. The respondents who said working from home increases their productivity are most likely describing the best conditions they have experienced, not necessarily the average of all their remote work experiences.

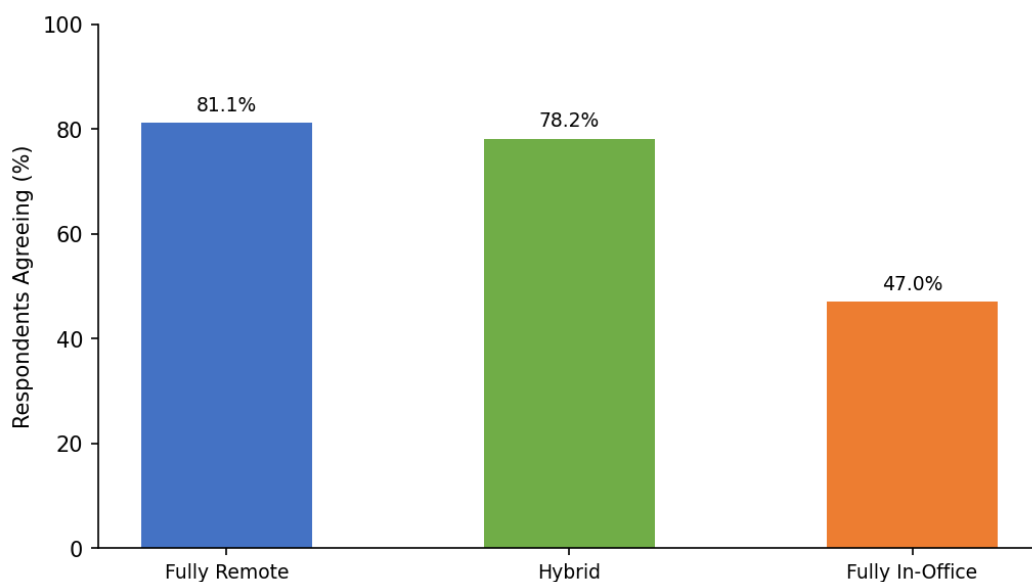


Figure 2: *Percentage of Respondents Who Believe Working from Home Increases Productivity by Current Work Arrangement.*

Flexibility

The highest agreement rate in the entire survey was for the flexibility question. A total of 89% of respondents said that working from home gives more flexibility. This near-universal agreement suggests that flexibility is the one benefit of remote work that almost everyone recognizes, regardless of whether they currently work remotely, in an office, or in a hybrid arrangement. Even the majority of fully in-office workers agreed that working from home offers greater flexibility, which shows that this perception is not just a product of personal preference or current arrangement.

Kelliher and Anderson (2008) found that employees with flexible working arrangements reported significantly higher job satisfaction and stronger organizational commitment than those without such arrangements. This is relevant because it confirms that flexibility is not just a nice-to-have. It has measurable effects on how employees feel about their jobs and their employer. However, Kelliher and Anderson also found that flexible workers worked harder and longer than their non-flexible counterparts. The freedom that comes with flexibility seemed to create a sense of obligation that employees expressed through greater effort.

This tension between flexibility and work intensification is one of the more important nuances in this area of the research. People value the ability to manage their own time, whether that means handling a personal task during the day or adjusting their schedule around family commitments. But that same flexibility often leads to a blurring of the boundary between work and personal life, where the convenience of being at home turns into an implicit expectation of constant availability. The 89% agreement rate on flexibility in this survey captures the upside of that equation. The time savings results discussed below capture the downside.

Time Savings

Despite the near-universal agreement that working from home is more flexible, only 42% of respondents said they believe it saves more time. This is a meaningful gap that the data captures very clearly. Flexibility and time savings are related concepts but they are not the same thing, and the survey results make that distinction visible.

The most straightforward explanation for the gap is that commute time is saved but that additional work time fills the space. When the boundary between home and work is unclear, many people simply work longer. Felstead and Henseke (2017) found exactly this pattern, where remote workers reported more difficulty switching off from work at the end of the day and worked with greater intensity than their in-office counterparts. If a person saves 60 minutes in commute time but then works an extra 60 minutes because they are already at their desk and the laptop is open, the net time savings is zero. This is very likely what the 58% who said remote work does not save time are experiencing in practice.

Golden et al. (2006) also pointed to the complication of family-to-work conflict, where being at home meant that household demands and interruptions could consume time that would otherwise have been available for focused work. For employees with significant family responsibilities, working from home does not always free up time. It can sometimes create more demands on the same hours. The time savings question is one where the survey data adds something genuinely useful to the conversation by separating it clearly from the flexibility question.

Physical Health

A total of 76% of respondents attributed greater physical health risks to working from home. This covers risks such as neck pain, back pain, and leg discomfort from extended sitting. This finding is in strong agreement with what the research literature has documented. Mann and Holdsworth (2003)

found that teleworkers reported more physical health symptoms than office workers, which included musculoskeletal discomfort, headaches, and eye strain. They attributed these findings partly to the ergonomic shortcomings of home workspaces, where employees often work on furniture that was not designed for an eight-hour workday.

The reality is that most people do not have a proper ergonomic desk, an adjustable chair, or a correctly positioned monitor at home. Many employees work from the couch, the kitchen table, or even the bed, especially in the early stages of a remote work arrangement. These positions put real stress on the spine, the neck, and the joints over extended periods. The office, on the other hand, typically provides furniture and equipment that meets at least a minimum ergonomic standard. This is a meaningful physical health advantage of in-office work that does not always receive attention in conversations about remote work.

Sardeshmukh et al. (2012) found that telework introduced physical demands that came from the home environment itself. These demands led to higher exhaustion for some remote workers. The survey results reflect a broad awareness of this issue among respondents. The 76% who identified working from home as the greater source of physical risk are most likely drawing on their own experience with discomfort, fatigue, or the awareness that their home setup is not ideal for the demands of a full working day.

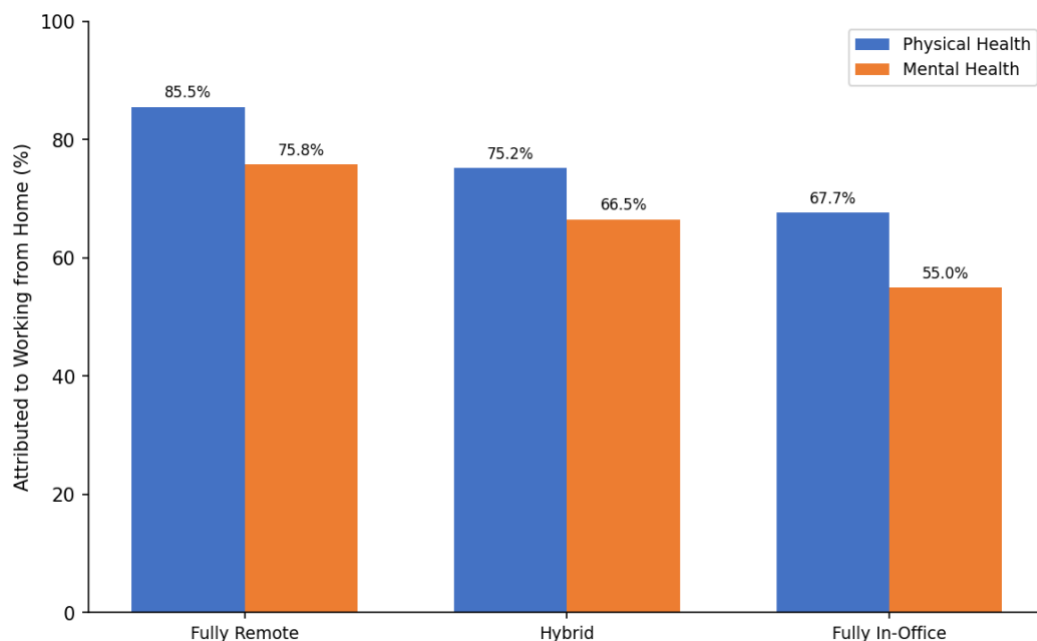


Figure 3: *Percentage of Respondents Attributing Physical and Mental Health Risks to Working from Home by Current Work Arrangement.*

Mental Health

About 66% of respondents said that working from home has greater potential to cause mental health problems such as stress, anxiety, and depression. The remaining 34% attributed these risks to office work. Both answers are grounded in real experience. Office environments are not stress-free.

Pressure from management, difficult coworkers, rigid schedules, and long commutes are all genuine sources of psychological strain for office-based employees. The 34% who identified the office as the greater mental health risk are not wrong. They are describing a different set of stressors.

The academic research confirms that mental health risks exist on both sides but appear to be higher for remote workers in many documented cases. Mann and Holdsworth (2003) found that teleworkers experienced significantly more negative emotions than office workers, with loneliness, irritability, and worry being notably more common among those who worked from home. Sardeshmukh et al. (2012) found that role ambiguity and reduced access to feedback and support contributed to higher exhaustion and lower engagement for remote employees whose organizational support was inadequate.

Lautsch et al. (2009) offered an important qualification to these findings by showing that the mental health effects of remote work were heavily influenced by management quality. When supervisors communicated frequently, shared information openly, and focused on supporting rather than monitoring their remote employees, the psychological risks of remote work were reduced. This means that the mental health outcomes of working from home are not entirely determined by the arrangement itself. Organizations have real influence over how remote work affects their employees' well-being, and that influence depends on how they choose to manage people who are not physically present.

The key takeaway from both the survey and the literature is that full-time remote work creates real psychological risks, especially for employees who already tend toward isolation or who struggle to maintain a clear separation between their work and personal lives. Those risks are manageable, but they require deliberate attention from both employees and the organizations that employ them.

Social Contact

A total of 71% of respondents said they believe working from home prevents them from staying in contact with other people. This is one of the clearest and most consistent findings in the entire survey. Social connection at work is not simply a personal preference or a secondary concern. It affects how people feel about their jobs, how effectively teams collaborate, and how strong an organization's culture is over time. When employees are separated from their colleagues for extended periods, the relationships that hold teams together begin to weaken.

Hislop and Axtell (2007) made an important observation about the specific type of social interaction that remote work eliminates. It is not only formal meetings or scheduled calls that are lost. The informal and spontaneous exchanges that happen naturally when people share a physical space are very difficult to replicate through technology. A quick question to a nearby colleague, an unplanned discussion in the hallway, or a casual conversation over lunch all serve functions that go beyond their surface content. They build familiarity, establish trust, and transfer knowledge in ways that structured video calls rarely match.

Gajendran and Harrison (2007) found that employees who telecommuted more than 2.5 days per week developed measurably weaker ties with their coworkers compared to those who telecommuted

less frequently. Golden et al. (2006) added that the social challenges of remote work were not limited to the professional sphere. They also included the difficulty of maintaining clear role boundaries at home, where family demands and professional responsibilities competed for the same space and time. The 71% who said working from home limits social contact are identifying a cost that the research literature has consistently documented.

Focus

About 61% of respondents said the office is a better environment for focus and concentration. This is a clear majority, but it is also worth paying attention to the 39% who said they focus better at home. These are not small numbers on either side, and together they confirm that focus is a highly individual experience. The best environment for concentrated work is not the same for every person.

For employees with busy households, young children, or limited personal space, the office may offer a level of structure and quiet that simply cannot be replicated at home. The act of going to an office creates a mental shift that many people find helpful for separating work mode from home mode. Bailey and Kurland (2002) noted that the ability to concentrate without household interruptions was one of the things that remote workers valued most, which means that for some employees, the home environment genuinely does provide better focus conditions, particularly for those who live alone or who have a dedicated and quiet home office space.

For people who find open-plan offices noisy and socially demanding, the home can be a much better environment for deep, focused work. The 39% who said they focus better at home are likely in this category. Organizations that assume all employees will concentrate better in the office are not accounting for this real variation. A thoughtful hybrid policy that gives employees some choice about where they do their most concentrated work is more likely to produce good outcomes than a blanket in-office requirement.

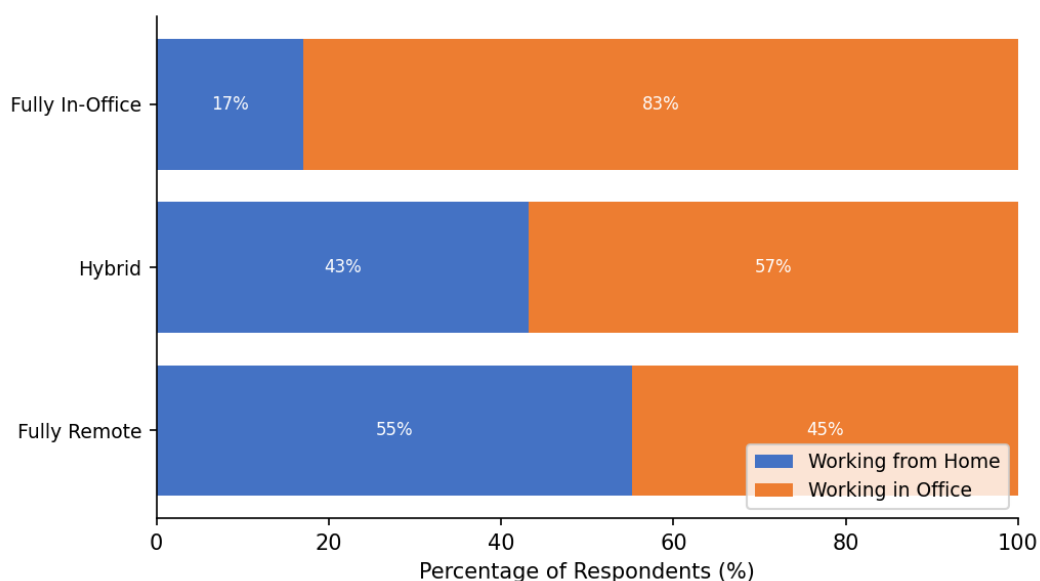


Figure 4: *Work Type Perceived to Support Focus by Current Work Arrangement.*

Work Preferences

The most striking finding in the entire survey is about overall preference. When asked which work arrangement they prefer most, 48% of respondents chose a hybrid model. Only 33% chose fully in-office work, and just 19% preferred working fully from home. These numbers tell a very clear story. Most employees do not want an extreme in either direction. They want a balanced arrangement that gives them the benefits of both environments without forcing them to give up either one entirely.

This preference for hybrid work was consistent across most demographic groups but with meaningful variations. Technology sector employees showed the strongest preference for remote or hybrid arrangements, which reflects the nature of their work and the higher-than-average rate of remote work experience in that sector. Healthcare and Retail workers leaned more toward in-office or hybrid options, which reflects the physical demands of their roles and their lower exposure to sustained remote work. Older respondents, particularly those 45 and above, preferred in-office or hybrid arrangements more often than younger respondents. Among those who currently work fully remote, 42% preferred working from home. Among those who work fully in-office, only 8% preferred remote work. Hybrid workers favored the mixed model overwhelmingly at 66%.

Allen et al. (2015) found that moderate telecommuting, rather than full-time remote work, tended to produce the best outcomes for satisfaction and performance. The survey preference data aligns with this finding. The largest group of respondents chose the middle ground, not the extremes. de Menezes and Kelliher (2011) found that the outcomes of flexible work depended heavily on individual factors and organizational context, which means that a hybrid policy that works well in one setting may need to be adjusted in another. The preference data from this survey does not suggest that one single hybrid structure is right for everyone. It suggests that giving employees some degree of real choice is itself a meaningful part of what makes a hybrid policy successful.

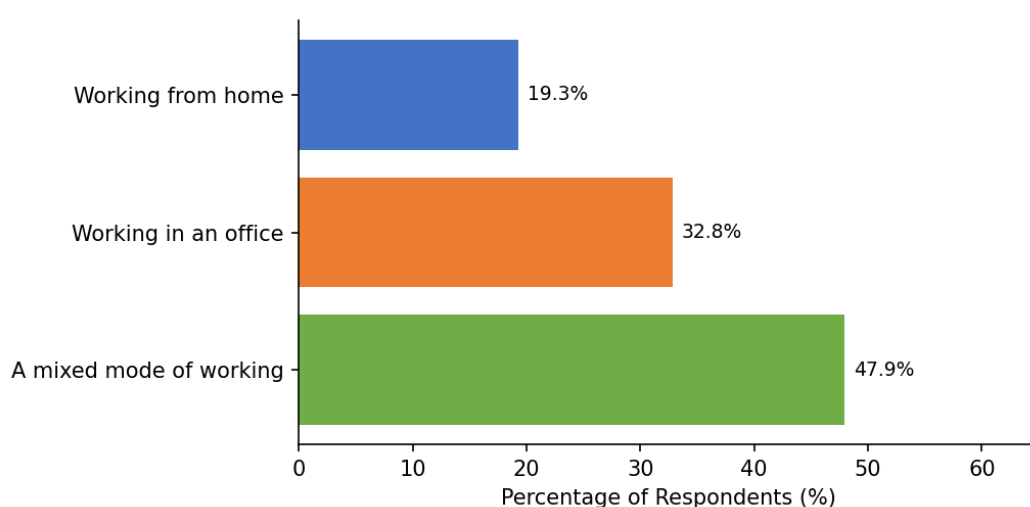


Figure 5: Overall Distribution of Preferred Work Type (N = 1,000).

Table 2: Work Preference by Current Work Arrangement (%)

Work Arrangement	WFH (%)	Office (%)	Mixed (%)
Fully Remote	42.1	24.9	33.0
Hybrid	10.7	23.1	66.3
Fully In-Office	8.3	53.7	38.0

Demographic Patterns

The cross-tabulations in this study revealed several consistent patterns across demographic groups that add important depth to the overall findings. Age was one of the most consistent moderators across questions. Older respondents, particularly those 45 and above, were more likely to say the office keeps them more focused and more likely to prefer in-office or hybrid arrangements. Younger respondents between 18 and 24 showed more openness toward working from home but were more divided on the productivity question than older groups. This pattern may reflect generational differences in how people define productivity, what they expect from their working environment, and the life circumstances that make each arrangement more or less practical.

Industry differences were equally clear. Technology workers had the highest rates of prior remote work experience at 75%, compared to 57% for Healthcare workers. Technology workers also showed stronger belief that working from home increases productivity and expressed stronger preference for remote or hybrid work. Healthcare and Retail workers showed the opposite pattern, with more skepticism toward remote work and a stronger preference for in-office arrangements. These differences make sense given that many Healthcare and Retail roles require physical presence, and that employees in those fields have far less experience with sustained remote work.

Current work arrangement emerged as one of the strongest predictors of survey responses across all questions. Fully remote workers were the most likely to say working from home increases productivity, provides flexibility, and is their preferred arrangement. Fully in-office workers were the most skeptical about remote work productivity and the most likely to prefer the office. Hybrid workers were the most likely to prefer the mixed model and showed the most balanced responses across all questions. This pattern could mean that people adapt to and find value in whatever arrangement they are currently in, or it could mean that employees self-select into arrangements that already match their preferences. Either way, the data confirms that current arrangement is deeply connected to expressed opinion, which organizations should keep in mind when interpreting employee feedback about work policies.

Conclusion

This study set out to understand how 1,000 employees perceive the impacts of working remotely and working in an office across six major dimensions: productivity, physical health, mental health, social contact, focus, and overall work preference. The results offer a detailed picture that neither fully supports nor fully rejects remote work as a better option. Both work environments come with real strengths and real costs, and the data makes both sides of that argument visible.

The benefits of working from home are clearly recognized across the sample. The large majority of respondents said it increases productivity and provides greater flexibility. These perceptions are consistent with what the research literature has found for voluntary remote work arrangements. Bloom et al. (2015) demonstrated a 13% productivity gain in a controlled experiment, and Allen et al. (2015) found strong associations between telecommuting and higher satisfaction and commitment. The feelings that respondents expressed about the benefits of remote work are grounded in real and documented phenomena.

At the same time, the survey makes it equally clear that remote work carries significant costs that most employees recognize. Most respondents attributed greater physical health risks to working from home. The pain and physical discomfort that come from poor home ergonomics and reduced daily movement are real concerns that the research literature also confirms, as Mann and Holdsworth (2003) found that teleworkers reported more physical symptoms than office workers. Most respondents also said that working from home limits social contact and that the office is a better environment for focus. The mental health findings were more divided, with 66% pointing to remote work as the greater source of risk and 34% identifying the office, which reflects the genuinely complex relationship between work environment and psychological well-being.

One of the most important things this study confirms is that the effects of remote work are not the same for everyone. They vary by industry, age group, and current work arrangement. A software developer who works alone from a quiet home office will have a very different experience than a Healthcare professional whose role requires physical presence and constant in-person interaction. Organizations that design one-size-fits-all work policies without accounting for this variation are unlikely to get the best outcomes from their workforce.

The clearest and most consistent finding across all groups is the preference for hybrid work. Nearly half of all respondents chose a hybrid arrangement as their preferred option, well ahead of the 33% who preferred full in-office work and the 19% who preferred full remote work. This preference makes practical sense. Hybrid work offers the flexibility and autonomy of remote work on some days while preserving the social connection and structured environment of the office on others. Gajendran and Harrison (2007) found that moderate telecommuting produced better outcomes than full-time remote work for most employees, and de Menezes and Kelliher (2011) found that the success of flexible arrangements depended heavily on implementation. Together, these findings support the idea that hybrid work is not just a popular preference. It is likely also the arrangement that best manages the real trade-offs between both environments.

For organizations deciding how to structure their work policies in the years ahead, these findings carry a clear message. Employees want balance. They want the freedom to work from home some of the time, and they want the social and professional environment of the office the rest of the time. A policy that forces employees into one extreme or the other is likely to produce dissatisfaction and missed opportunities for both productivity and well-being. A thoughtfully designed hybrid policy that gives employees real choice, clear structure, and adequate organizational support represents the most practical path forward based on what this data shows. Future research should continue to examine how different hybrid structures affect team performance, mental health, and physical well-being over longer time periods, since the research by Lautsch et al. (2009) suggests that management practices and organizational support are just as important as the arrangement itself.

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